

INVENTORY · STACK · STRUCTURE

principles

Declared statements — short stated principles, each with a one-line justification.

How we make calls when the spec is silent.

Default to the cheaper-to-reverse choice. Reversible calls don't need a meeting; only the irreversible ones do.

Name the actor, never the system. "The PM decides" lands; "the process decides" hides accountability.

Write down the bet on the same slide as the choice. The decision and its predicted outcome live together — the calibration loop depends on it.

Form follows function. Let the audience's need shape the layout, not the other way around.

One main idea per slide. If you can't summarise it in one sentence, split it across two slides.

How we resolve conflicts — top wins.

01

Default to the choice that is cheaper to

02

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03

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Form follows function.

05

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The editorial canon.

Plain words beat clever ones. If a board member needs a glossary, the slide failed.

One claim per sentence. Compound claims hide the one a reader would dispute.

Show the number, then the verdict. Evidence first earns the conclusion that follows.

Cut the adverb, keep the verb. "Grew sharply" is weaker than "doubled."

End on the decision, not the summary. The last slide should ask for something.

What we optimise for, in no particular order.

Reversibility over consensus. Make the cheap-to-undo call now; reserve the meeting for the one-way doors.

Clarity over completeness. A slide that says one true thing beats one that says five hedged ones.

Ownership over process. Name the person; processes don't get paged.

Evidence over instinct. Write the prediction down so the instinct can be scored later.

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When NOT to reach for principles.

Aspirations, not principles. "Be empathetic" is a value, not a principle. Principles are decision rules — they say what to do when two options conflict. Reach for content if it's a values statement.

Long per-principle prose. Each justification is one sentence. If a principle needs a paragraph of context, give it its own slide and let principles act as the index.

Hedged statements. "We try to default to X" reads as a wish. Drop the hedge — principles are declared, not negotiated. "Default to X" lands harder.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

- `actors` — rules attach to named owners, not shared tenets
- `tldr` — single-line takeaways without justification body
- `list` — items are short bullets without title + body shape
- `cards-stack` — each principle needs two sentences of body